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MEDIA STRATEGY FOR PROMOTING SDG'S LOCALIZATION – A MAPPING STUDY

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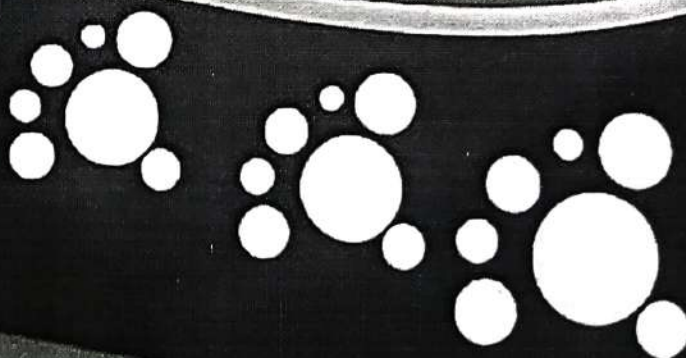
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MEDIA STRATEGY FOR PROMOTING SDG'S LOCALIZATION – A MAPPING STUDY

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Abstract

Media has a pivotal role in endorsing, promoting as well as educating and monitoring the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG's). Media acts as a crucial stakeholder in the dynamics and interplay of various parties involved in the planning, implementation and execution of objectives related to the SDG's. In this context media plays multiple roles in the SDG's implementation and they include the role of an information disseminator, role of a monitoring agency, role of advocacy, role of inculcating a participatory culture that can lead to social empowerment and the role of a creator of an Empowered Citizenry having a decision making ability. In a country like India, achieving the SDGs is only possible through localization, given the diversity of issues at the local level and the magnitude of the challenges. Every state in the country with its diverse socio-economic and political conditions presents unique challenges for the implementation of SDG's. Thus localization of each and every goal related to SDG's need to be presented in localized tone, terms and atmosphere. In this backdrop the role of media becomes more relevant and crucial as it is one of the fulcrums which connect the implementation agencies and the agents.

The present paper tries to analyze the role played by the media in delivering the localized SDG's content by performing a media mapping study. The two language newspapers i.e. Eenadu and Sakshi and two English newspapers i.e. The Hindu and the Indian Express were selected for the study. The study conducted a mapping exercise covering SDG's related content i.e. content that explicitly mentioned about SDG and published in the selected Print Media in three phases i.e. from January 2015 to December 2015, from January 2020 to December 2020 and from January 2021 to December 2021 for doing a comparative analysis. The findings indicated that among the identified roles media is fulfilling the role of the Information Provider and as a monitor to certain extent but is neglecting the other three roles. The analysis indicates that media is not playing a pro-active role in the channelization of information related to SDG's localization. Media is also concentrating only some goals without a comprehensive coverage all the important objectives related to the SDG's. The study indicated that the biggest challenge for the media is localizing the SDG goals and make people to connect and participate more in their implementation. Finally it can be deduced that media must fulfill its role of creator of

empowered citizenry that can ultimately reduce the societal imbalances through the implementation of SDG goals there by paving the way for a more equitable society .

Keywords : Sustainable Development Goals, SDG's Localization, Media Mapping, Participatory Communication

INTRODUCTION

"Access to information is not only a basic human right, but also an important tool for promoting the rule of law and ensuring other rights as well as goals under the SDGs. It is therefore an enabler for sustainable development in areas such as health, environment, addressing poverty and fighting corruption"

INTER-AGENCY AND EXPERT GROUP ON SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT GOAL INDICATORS

The Inter-agency and Expert Group on Sustainable Development Goal Indicators IAEG-SDGs during its tenth meeting on 21 - 24 October 2019 in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia has agreed that the access to information, which was previously on tier II, indicator 16.10 is now on tier I indicating the shifting focus on the importance of the guarantees on access to information and the success of the Sustainable development goals. Thus access to information is not only a basic human right, but also an important tool for promoting the rule of law and ensuring other rights as well as goals under the SDGs. It is therefore an enabler for sustainable development in areas such as health, environment, addressing poverty and fighting corruption. **(IAEG - SDGs)**. Thus communication and public access to information is regarded as an essential ingredient for the success of the any development goals. Media can act as a communication, transparency and accountability channel for all stakeholders. Media in all its forms can play a significant role in the delivery of a development agenda through ensuring that citizens are well informed. In the context of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), media is an integral part of the ecosystem with regard to raising awareness and sensitizing people about the goals, targets and their relevance and highlighting efforts at the national and local levels **(Abdulai, Kagumire and Geoghegan, 2018)**.

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development adopted in 2015 by all 193 United Nations Member States set out a roadmap to transform our world. At the heart of "Agenda 2030" are 17 Sustainable Development Goals and 169 related targets that address the most urgent challenges of our time. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) encompassing the social, economic and environmental aspects of development are framed to respond many intricate and complex development challenges. While governments collectively set the Goals, achieving the SDGs by 2030 will also require concerted actions by civil society, businesses, international bodies, regional organizations, and individuals, among other actors. Media plays a particularly critical role in supporting public dialogue, enhancing knowledge of ways to support sustainable development, and hold Governments accountable. Thus Media is critical actor for raising the awareness of the Goals, help galvanize further action and help

hold governments to account for Agenda 2030. (un.org/sustainabledevelopment/sdg-media-compact)

In the present day context the success of a universal concept like SDG's is primarily related to its interconnectedness and localization or regionalization of every goal to its target audiences. In its second Voluntary National Review (VNR) report at the High-Level Political Forum 2020, NITI Aayog released the third edition of the SDG India Index and the first district level SDG Index in which it has body has un-equivocally highlighted that in a country like India, achieving the SDGs is only possible through localization, given the diversity of issues at the local level and the magnitude of the challenges. (NITI- Aayog Report 2021-22). The NITI – Aayog document further emphasized that the central Government alone cannot achieve the SDGs and the success of the 2030 Agenda depends on forging effective partnerships between the government, state governments, private sector, civil society organizations, and the research and academic community. The Indian model of SDG localization is structured around four inter-related pillars operating sequentially and simultaneously at the national level, anchored by NITI Aayog in the centre and by respective state and UT governments at the sub-national level. The four foundational pillars in this model are creating institutional ownership, establishing a robust review and monitoring system, Developing capacities for integrating SDGs in planning and monitoring and finally Promoting a “whole-of-society” approach. Thus all the four pillars need a basic fulcrum i.e. media on which the dissemination of the entire localized SDG agenda can be done to the public in the regional public sphere.

AIM AND OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

The primary aim of the study is to analyze the current role played by the media in disseminating and advocating the information and implementation of SDG's in a regional context. To achieve this, the following are the different objective designed for the study.

- To conduct the literature review to analyze the different categories of information formats like news, analysis, articles, follow-up stories, editorials published in the regional media.
- The study analyze whether the published contents are primary or secondary or follow-up in nature as well as the framing used;
- To identify the level and extent of coverage of different goals or SDG areas by English and Telugu Media along with the regional editions.

METHODOLOGY

The two language newspapers i.e. Eenadu and Sakshi and two English newspapers i.e. The Hindu and the Indian Express were selected for the study. The study conducted a mapping exercise covering SDG's related content i.e. content that explicitly mentioned about SDG and published in the selected Print Media in three phases i.e. from January 2015 to December 2015, from January 2020 to December 2020 and from January 2021 to December 2021 for doing a comparative analysis. The study adopted the a detailed review of literature and policy documents through a Media Mapping exercise covering the SDG's related contents published in the selected Print Media Editions

The following major formats of News Stories were identified for the purpose of the study. They are Spot News, Analysis, Editorials, Views / Opinions, Letters to the Editor, Book Reviews, Interviews and Supplements. Content mapping study approach is helpful to analyze the content in terms of its format, relevance and timeliness. It can identify whether the information is suiting the intended audience or is the process focusing on the right content for the right audience that matches the reader's intent. It also helps in identifying the gaps and opportunities in the dissemination and formatting of the content.

THE CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK OF MEDIA ROLE IN IMPLEMENTATION OF SDG'S

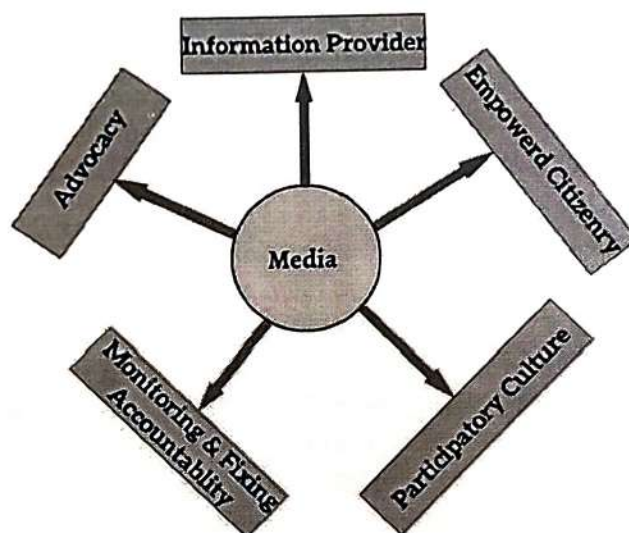


Figure 1: Conceptual Framework for media role in implementation of SDGs

A developing society is built on the pillars of inclusive, just and strong institutions and their capacity to encourage Citizens' participation. People's participation depends on the information they are given and this is directly connected to the media which has a role in shaping the policy and development agenda of the state, and has implications for the millions of people whose lives are affected (Titus, 2017). Thus media is a pre- condition for meaningful progress and implementation on the 2030 SDG Agenda. The following roles of media are identified to be playing key contribution to SDG's implementation and they are an information disseminator,, role of a monitoring agency, role of advocacy, role of inculcating a participatory culture that can lead to social empowerment and the role of a creator of an Empowered Citizenry having a decision making ability. Media can disseminate huge amounts of information regarding SDG's in the form of In order to measure the progress of SDGs, a huge amount of information will be generated in the form of news, articles, talk shows, videos, animation and so on (Grizzle, 2015). Media is an important instrument to create awareness

about the SDGs. Media's prime responsibility is its information dissemination role and through this role it can inform and influence public opinion about policies and programmes. Thus media act as channels of information and knowledge through which citizens communicate with each other and make informed decisions thereby encouraging and facilitating facilitate informed debates between diverse stakeholders in the society.

The proper use of information made available by media and various information providers depends on people's abilities to understand their information needs, and to locate, retrieve and evaluate the quality of the information they can access. Today, there is an extremely wide and diverse selection of information material, content, and resources available, particularly on the Internet, varying greatly in accuracy, reliability, and value. In addition to acting as a channel of information flow, independent, pluralist media subsequently contributes in building well-informed, critical and resilient citizens. Thus, instead of simply inform, media's goal should be to transform the thought process of citizens and empower them to shape their own development, and to participate, advocate and monitor for the successful delivery of the SDGs.

The agenda-setting theory of the media postulates that mass media have a large influence on audiences by their choice of what stories to consider newsworthy and how much prominence and space to give them. Agenda-setting theory's main postulate is salience transfer. Salience transfer is the ability of the mass media to transfer issues of importance from their mass media agendas to public agendas. The media agenda is the set of issues addressed by media sources and the public agenda which are issues the public consider important. The basic assumption that underlie most research on agenda-setting are that the press and the media do not reflect reality, they filter and shape it, and the media concentration on a few issues and subjects leads the public to perceive those issues as more important than other issues. Thus by different levels of agenda setting media suggests what the public should think about by the amount of coverage given and later media focuses on the characteristics of the issues suggesting how the people should think about the issue. Through agenda setting media plays an advocacy role there by influencing people's beliefs and actions. "The media doesn't tell us what to think; it tells us what to think about" is the underlying statement of agenda setting. (Bernard C. Cohen (1963))

Good governance is a pre-requisite to attain sustainable development in a nation. It is more likely that a government will be open to transparency and accountability if there is an enabling environment in the country for free speech, access to information and media freedom. It also denotes that citizens find it conducive to hold their government accountable, and can participate to ensure that their needs are met through the government. A free, pluralistic, professional and independent media, are fundamental to facilitate good and effective governance and promote responsive government in a nation (UNESCO, 2015). The media can perform the watchdog role of holding government more accountable and expose the abuses of power and resources through utilizing new media technologies combined with insightful investigative journalism. The media can promote accountability in government actions through monitoring the performance of public institutions, exposing any misconduct, providing feedbacks

and advocating for change (Cole et al., 2008). With regard to the overall accountability for the 2030 Agenda, the media can provide a platform to discuss and debate pertinent issues related to the SDGs. They can spread information on the status of progress and challenges in relation to the SDGs, highlight the human story behind the data and numbers, and put pressure on governments to take necessary action to effectively implement the SDGs.

Issues such as poverty alleviation and gender equality are often reported by international agencies such as the UN on a global platform. This can make the topics of

little interests to the readers, viewers or listeners due to being seemingly abstract and rather remote in nature (Thomas, 2014). Meanwhile, a peripheral topic can be brought to light and to the focus through covering an important story which has international interest. Journalists should always look out for contemporary, locally focused perspectives to make stories interesting to the readers, viewers or listeners (Thomas, 2014). News that is local and relevant and personalized resonates with local audiences (Titus, 2017). Thus media by localizing the SDG agenda can make its implementation more focused and understandable to the local audiences.

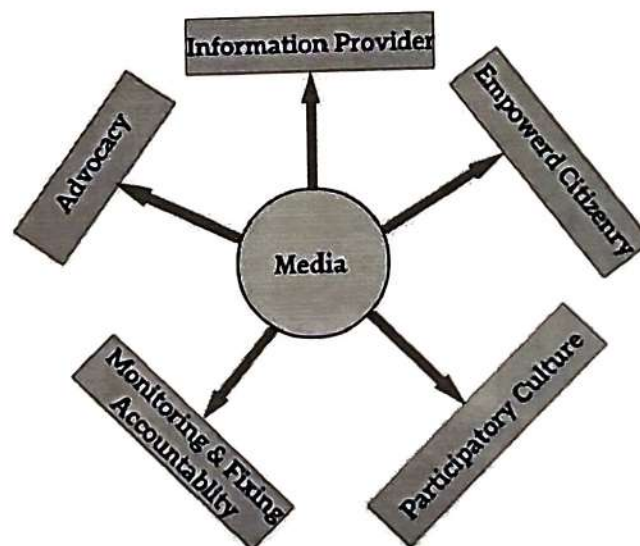
Participatory communication refers to two-way communication based on dialog between people, groups, and organizations, which empowers various stakeholders to equitably share and exchange information, knowledge, and experience. Participatory communication stresses the importance of cultural identity of local communities and of democratization and participation at all levels – international, national, local, and individual. However, the point of departure must be the community. It is at the community level that the problems of living conditions are discussed, and interactions with other communities are elicited (Servaes 1999; 2003). In order to share information, knowledge, trust, commitment, and a right attitude, participatory communication is very important. The International Commission for the Study of Communication Problems, chaired by Sean MacBride, argued that “this calls for a new attitude for overcoming stereotyped thinking and to promote more understanding of diversity and plurality, with full respect for the dignity and equality of peoples living in different conditions and acting in different ways” (MacBride 1980, 254).

The most developed form of participation is self-management of communication media. This principle implies the right to participation in the planning and production of media content. However, not everyone wants to or must be involved in its practical implementation. More important is that participation is made possible in the decision-making regarding the subjects treated in the messages and regarding the selection procedures. There are two major approaches to participatory communication. The first is the dialogical pedagogy of Paulo Freire (1970; 1973; 1983; 1994), and the second involves the ideas of access, participation, and self-management articulated in the UNESCO debates of the 1970s (Berrigan 1977; 1979). The Freirean argument works by a dual theoretical strategy implying dialogical communication. Although inspired to some extent by Sartre’s existentialism, a respect for the autonomous personhood of each human being, the more important source is a theology that demands respect for otherness – in this case that of another human being.

The second discourse about participatory communication is the UNESCO language about access, participation, and self-management from the 1977 meeting in Belgrade. The final report of that meeting defines the terms in the following way. First, “access” refers to the use of media for public service. It may be defined in terms of the opportunities available to the public to choose varied and relevant programs and to have a means of feedback to transmit its reactions and demands to production organizations. Second, “participation” implies a higher level of public involvement in communication systems than mere access. It includes the involvement of the public in the production process, and also in the management and planning of communication systems. Participation may be no more than representation and consultation of the public in decision-making. Third, “self-management” is the most advanced form of participation. In this case, the public exercises the power of decision-making within communication enterprises and is also fully involved in the formulation of communication policies and plans. Access by the community and participation of the community are to be considered key defining factors, as Berrigan eloquently summarizes: “Community media are media to which members of the community have access, for information, education, entertainment, when they want access. They are media in which the community participates, as planners, producers, and performers. They are the means of expression of the community, rather than for the community” (Berrigan 1979, 8)

ROLE OF MEDIA IN SDG'S DELIVERY

Figure: 2: Coverage of SDG's news items in English Newspapers in 2015, 2020 and in 2022



The study conducted a mapping exercise covering SDG's related content i.e. content that explicitly mentioned about SDG and published in the selected Print Media in two phases i.e. from January 2015 to December 2015, January 2021 to December 2021 and from January 2022 to December 2022. The

following are the analysis of the mapping exercise. Media has played the role of an information disseminator by presenting information from various sources and channels in a wide variety of formats. In the year 2015 a total of 55 news items related to SDG's were published by the English print media in the formats of event news, op-eds, editorials, views, letters to the editor, interviews etc. It is interesting to note that the total number of news items increased to 227 in the year 2020 and to 347 in the year 2021. There is an increase of total news items from the year 2015 to 2020 by 24% and from 2020 to 2021 by 65% in English language news papers. Majority of the news items published belonged to the category of event news in all three years accounting to 32%, 39% and 40% respectively followed by Views / Opinions category accounting for 25%, 29% and 31% respectively. The op-eds accounted for 40%, 25% and 24% in the years 2015, 2020 and 2021 respectively. It can be observed that there are no analytical stories in the year 2015 and 2020 and only 2 stories in 2021 and very few interviews and

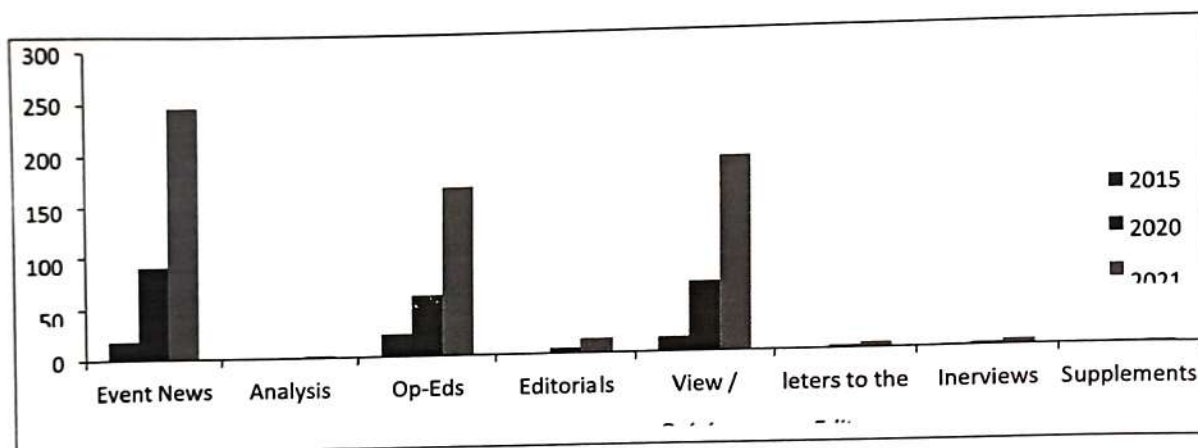
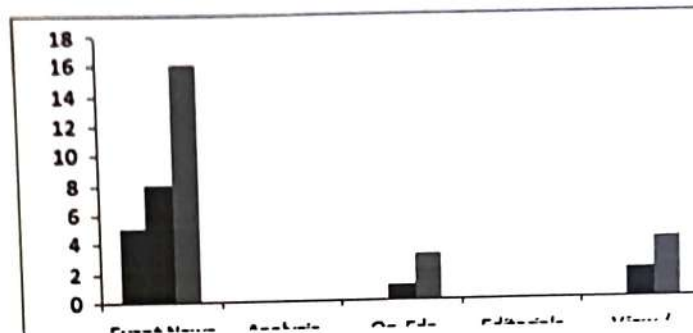


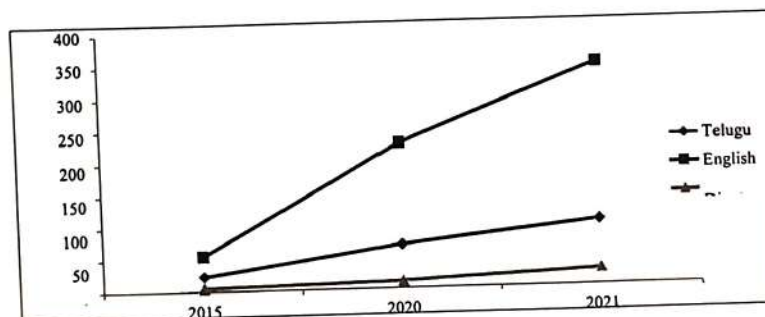
Figure: 3: Coverage of SDG's news items in Telugu Newspapers in 2015, 2020 and in 2022

The Telugu newspapers published a total of 23 news items related to SDG's in 2015 in various formats followed by 69 news items in the year 2020 and to 102 in the year 2021. There is an increase of total news items from the year 2015 to 2020 by 33% and from 2020 to 2021 by 67% in Telugu language news papers. The majority of the news items belonged to the category of Event news i.e. 70%, 69% and 62% in the years of 2015, 2020 and in 2021. The views / opinions constituted for 8%, 11% and 12% respectively. The data indicates that there are no special supplements in Telugu Newspapers and very few analytical stories and interviews. (Figure: 2)

The Telugu language district editions published 5 news items related to DG's in 2015 followed by 11 and 25 news items in 2020 and 2021 respectively. The majority of news items in the Telugu District Editions related to the category of Event news i.e. 100% in 2015 followed by 72% and 64% in 2020 and 2021 respectively. There are only very few news items related to Views and opinions and op-eds. There are no news items related to analysis, editorials, supplements, letters to the editor in the Telugu District Editions in 2015, 2020 and 2021 (Figure: 3)

Figure 4: Coverage of SDG's news items in Telugu District Editions in 2015, 2020 and in 2022

Thus the analysis of the various categories of news items published in English, Telugu language newspapers and in Telugu District Editions indicate that the manifold increase in the number of news items published in various categories from 2015 to 2020 and from 2020 to 2021 the increase is seen only in few categories of news items. (Figure: 4). The increase in the publishing of the news items in the categories of Event news and views and opinions indicates that both the English and Telugu Print media has performed the role of a news disseminator but has failed to perform the role of an advocacy as indicated by the very few items related to independent Analysis, interviews etc.

Figure 5: Coverage of SDG's news items in Telugu, English & District Editions in 2015, 2020 & 2022

The published contents on SDG issues has been increasing quite rapidly and increased from 2015 to 2020 and the increase is more pronounced from 2020 to 2021 in both the English and Telugu Print Media. The prevalence of more SDG related events and issues have resulted in the increasing of the bulk of the publishing of the news items but the lack of good supplemental information, feed back of the reader in the form of letters to the editor is missing from the content.

Figure 6: Coverage of SDG's goals in English language newspapers in 2015, 2020 & 2022

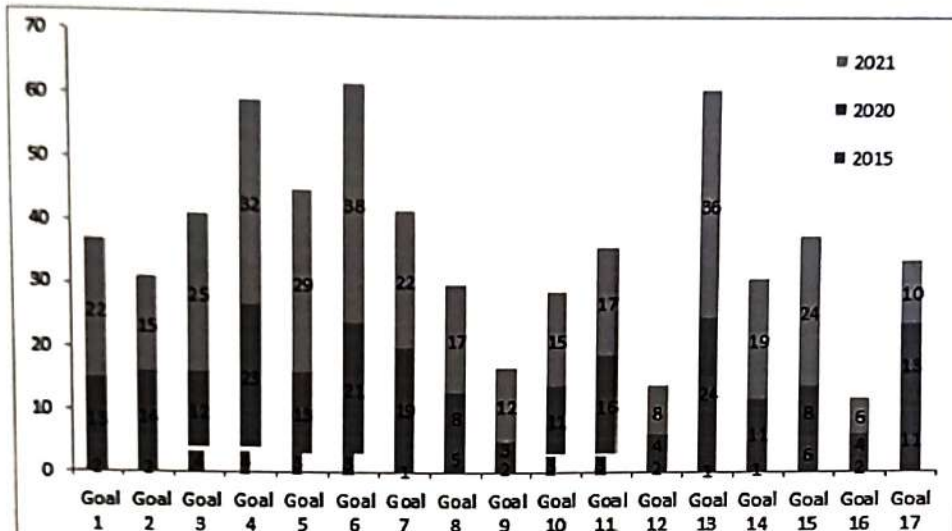
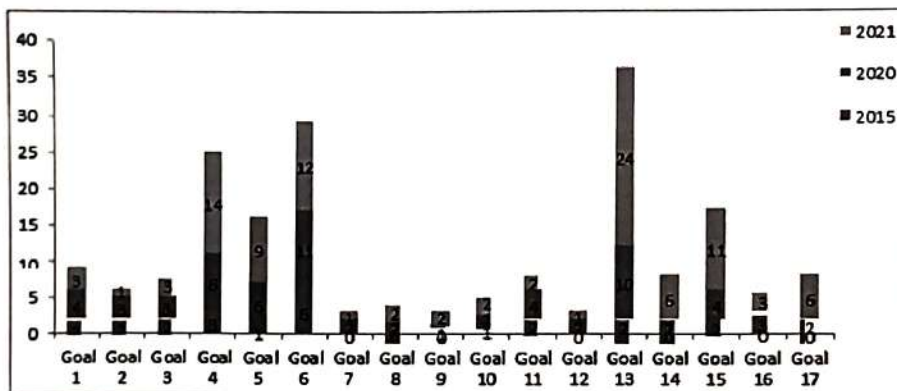


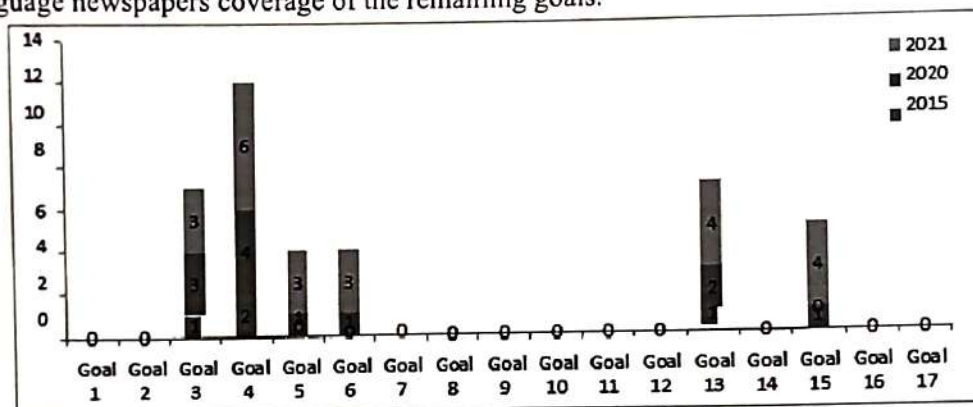
Figure 7: Coverage of SDG's goals in Telugu language newspapers in 2015, 2020 & 2022



The mapping exercise of the SDG goals shows that the Goal 4 (Quality education), Goal 5 (Gender Equity) and Goal 13 (Climate Action) featured more prominently in the year 2015, 2020 and in 2021 in both the English and Telugu language newspapers (Figure-5 & 6). The growth of the news items is more from 2020 to 2021 in Goal 4 by 71% in English and 57% in Telugu, Goal 5 by 66% in English and 44% in Telugu and Goal 13 by 66% in English and 41% in Telugu. The spurt in the increase of the news items related to Goal 4 and Goal 5 is due to the emphasis given by the Government agencies on various schemes related to girl education, gender imbalances etc. The increase in the news items related to the Goal 13 is due to the occurrence of more climate related adverse events like heavy rains, floods and draught etc. The Goal 17, Goal 16, Goal 12, Goal 9 have received very low coverage in the years 2015, 2020 and in 2021 in both the English and Telugu language newspapers.

In a country like India, achieving the SDGs is only possible through localization, given the diversity of issues at the local level and the magnitude of the challenges. Every state in the country with its diverse socio-economic and political conditions presents unique challenges for the implementation of SDG's. Thus localization of each and every goal related to SDG's need to be presented in localized tone, terms and atmosphere. In this backdrop the role of media becomes more relevant and crucial as it is one of the fulcrums

which connect the implementation agencies and the agents. The coverage of SDG goals in regional district editions is substantially lower when compared with that of the Telugu regional news papers and English language newspapers coverage of the remaining goals.



The data analysis of the regional district editions coverage of the SDG goals indicate that there coverage of only Goal 3, Goal 4, Goal 5, Goal 6, Goal 13, Goal 15 only and there is absolutely no coverage of the remaining goals. First, despite a significant increase in the number of media coverage on SDGs since 2015 to 2020 and from 2020 to 2021 the Print media in the State of Andhra Pradesh has not played a pro-active role in the SDG localization. The emphasis on the event news and lack of any sort of analysis and feature stories indicate that the media has adopted a passive role. Even though media is regarded as a power watchdog in the public sphere related to politics its role in the development / participatory communication is much to be debated. The lack of coverage of implementation of majority of SDG goals, an independent analysis of the progress in the Telugu and the district editions is the justification to the fact that media has not played the role of a watch dog to its brim.

The process of SDG localization involves the development of a media literate citizen who is able to think, analyze and act independently. The creation of an empowered citizenry who have the decision making capacity for their own improvement there by paving way for the nation's development is imperative for the success of any development goal. For this media has to be independent and give unbiased information to enhance the power of the public and society. The analysis of the SDG goals coverage the district editions indicates that media has not played any role to bridge the gap between implementation agencies and the agents of change.

Thus in order to engage media more effectively in the process of Agenda 2030 of SDG realization media should create more partnerships with the local change agents and disseminate more information about the opportunities available for the development at the regional levels. The media should focus on the specialization reporting such as participatory communication whereby they have to involve the people mandate more in the process of delivery of the information. The information of the SDG goals in terms of the development success stories can be given to motivate and make people more participative.

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